

Espressivo

The Timeless Power of Music to Heal Humanity

I. An American Hero

In the midst of a raging war sat one still man, his eyes locked onto another man. The motionless man awaited a signal, a cue from the other, to begin the half-hour operation. Eighty-eight delicate keys lay in front of him. With the push of these keys, he had the power to alter the complexion of the war. Twenty-three-year-old pianist Harvey Lavan Cliburn Jr. was competing in the final round of the inaugural International Tchaikovsky Piano Competition in Moscow on April 14, 1958.

At the height of the Cold War, the prospect of nuclear annihilation seized the world in constant fear. The U.S. and USSR's fight over dominance created intense hostilities. After their thumping victory with the launching of Sputnik, the Soviet Union sought to display their superiority in the arts as well. This, in turn, led to the creation of the International Tchaikovsky Competition. Held in Moscow, the competition invited fifty pianists from nineteen countries; the Soviets envisioned it would showcase the Soviet pianists as "the best in the world." The jury included pianists Emil Gilels and Sviatoslav and composers Dmitri Kabalevsky and Dmitri Shostakovich, all iconic figures in Russian music.

Van Cliburn, one of the fifty pianists invited to compete in the first Tchaikovsky Competition, was American. He began studying the piano at the age of three with his mother and made his orchestral debut with the Houston Symphony at twelve; at seventeen, he enrolled in The Julliard School through a scholarship. In 1954, he won the Leventritt Competition, a prestigious international competition. But, three years later, Van Cliburn found his career stagnating as he was \$7,000 in debt. His teacher, Madame Rosina Lhévinne—going against the recommendation from his managers at Columbia Artists to embark on a European tour—encouraged him to enter the Tchaikovsky competition. With a \$1,000 grant from the Martha Baird Rockefeller Aid to Music program to fund the flight to Moscow and all other

expenses paid by the Soviet government, Van Cliburn made the journey into the Soviet Union.

Van Cliburn was welcomed with a warm reception at Moscow. He recalled, “I was just so involved with the sweet and friendly people who were so passionate about music.” Van Cliburn became an immediate favorite from the preliminary rounds, amazing the audiences with stunning interpretations of Bach, Barber, Beethoven, Brahms, Chopin, Kabalevsky, Mozart, Liszt, Prokofiev, Rachmaninoff, Scriabin, Taneyev, and Tchaikovsky. The emotion pouring from his performances moved the Soviet audience; they did not see a man from a belligerent nation but rather a musician who shared a common love for the piece he was performing.

In the final round, Van Cliburn performed Tchaikovsky’s First Concerto and Rachmaninoff’s Third Concerto. The lyrical voice from the piano resonated in the concert hall as Van Cliburn played. He won over the hearts of the Soviets with his “magnolia blossom” sound and virtuosity. The performance captivated the audience as the emotions from the music came through his phrasing and musicality. With his performance, the Soviets rediscovered their love and beauty of music out of the chaos and hate in the Cold War; they remembered their music that had been lost and forgotten in the turmoil of war. Van Cliburn’s playing was a cry for freedom that the Soviets had longed for.

The audience began to roar as Van Cliburn triumphantly held the last chord in his program. He was then welcomed by a standing ovation that lasted eight minutes; the audience exuberantly chanted, “First prize!” The judges raved about the performance as well. Pianist Sviatoslav Richter, one of the judges, described Van Cliburn as “a genius,” scoring his performance 100 out of 100. However, the brilliance of Van Cliburn’s performance proved to be problematic for one reason: the Soviets did not intend for him to win.

The judges tentatively asked Soviet Premier Nikita Khrushchev if they were allowed to award the first-place prize to an American. Khrushchev bluntly asked, “Is he the best?” The judges responded yes.

“Then give him the prize!”

Van Cliburn was awarded the Gold medal in the competition. Fame unprecedented for classical musicians rushed towards Van Cliburn; he instantly became an American hero. A *Time* magazine cover gave him the title “The Texan Who Conquered Russia.” Van Cliburn transformed into a symbol of understanding between the U.S. and the USSR; he was able to make both sides forget about their differences and focus on their shared love for music. Though his career would ultimately decline, never reaching the same heights as the glory achieved by winning the Tchaikovsky Competition, the name Van Cliburn still does and will always hold a special place in Russian music.

II. An Intermission

After Van Cliburn’s catapult to extraordinary fame with his win in Moscow, a piano competition was named after him in honor of his legacy of displaying the transformative power of music. The quadrennial Van Cliburn Competition immediately grew into one of the most prestigious piano competitions after its inauguration in 1962. Embracing the hospitality Van Cliburn received from residents in Moscow, the competition has a unique tradition of arranging for its competitors to house with host families, sparking great friendships that last for a lifetime. Every four years, the world’s best pianists, aged eighteen to thirty, compete for the highly prized gold medal in Fort Worth, Texas, live in front of an audience and streamed to millions of viewers worldwide. Winning the competition is life-changing; it can catapult careers to great heights.

III. The Van Cliburn Legacy

This story of a pianist conquering the world in 1958 was behind the Van Cliburn Foundation’s decision to allow Russian pianists to compete in the Van Cliburn International Piano Competition amidst the Russian invasion of Ukraine. The sixteenth edition of the Cliburn Competition presented a difficult circumstance. In addition to a pandemic ravaging the world, the Russian invasion of Ukraine prompted other competitions to ban Russian

competitors. The World Federation of International Music Competitions (WFIMC) banished the Tchaikovsky Competition, the very competition Van Cliburn had won to inspire the Cliburn's creation, from membership. Two other major piano competitions, the Honens International Piano Competition and the Dublin International Piano Competition, had expelled Russian pianists. There were intense calls for the Cliburn to follow other organizations' boycotts of Russian artists, pressuring it to ban them.

However, on March 3, 2022, months before the competition, the Cliburn released a statement. Inspired by Van Cliburn's legacy, it had defiantly decided to allow Russian pianists: "The story of Van Cliburn and his Cold War victory at the first International Tchaikovsky Competition in Moscow inspired the world as a testament to the transcendence of art, even at the most tense of times between two superpowers. As he himself said: 'Since we know that classical music is timeless and everlasting, it is precisely the eternal verities inherent in classical music that remain a spiritual beacon for people all over the world.' "

Jacques Marquis, the Cliburn president and CEO, further explained the competition's decision: "Especially for us, we were founded by this man's legacy who in 1958 won the Tchaikovsky in Moscow in the Cold War. Van Cliburn himself brought people together through music. He was never talking about politics, but music; the love of music and how it can bring people all over the world together. Yes, we were born from this inspiration that music can bring people from all boundaries together, and we should not ban or discriminate on these premises."

IV. The Quest for Glory

Thus, seventy-two pianists, fifteen of whom were Russian, embarked on their quest to win one of classical music's grandest prizes. The climate of the competition was emotional against the backdrop of war. Conductor Marin Alsop, the jury chair of the Cliburn, commented, "You can feel the intense emotion of what's going on. Maybe part of it is projecting onto it, but I think it's very genuine from them." Dmytro Choni, the only Ukrainian competitor, was on a personal mission to heal his hurting homeland

through the competition: “The goal must be to unite people, to give a kind of a relief from what’s going on in the world. Music can be a cure, a treatment. It has always been like this, but maybe in these times, it is especially relevant.” Seventy-two dwindled to thirty as the competitors for the live rounds in Texas were selected. Then, six remained, competing against each other to win the ultimate prize in the final.

Jeff King, the Cliburn board chairman, emphasized the true purpose of the competition as he announced the finalists: “You have affirmed that we all have more in common than not, that we are all brothers and sisters together, and that we all share the same dreams. Van Cliburn said, ‘If you hold on to the beauty and inspiration and the clarity that is music, you will have an anchor and you will not be swayed ...’ Thank you for being who you are ... you bring the healing energy that is music to our world.”

Each of the six finalists, of whom there was a Ukrainian and a Russian, performed two piano concertos with the Fort Worth Symphony Orchestra conducted by Marin Alsop.

V. Triumph

Out of the finalists emerged an unforeseen shining light that had radiated brighter than all the other competitors for the entirety of the Cliburn—not a six-foot-four American, a Russian, a Ukrainian, but an eighteen-year-old South Korean pianist named Yunchan Lim.

Yunchan had astonished everyone in the previous rounds. His magisterial performances captivated the audiences, similar to the spellbinding awe Van Cliburn had cast many years ago in Moscow. His final-round performance of Rachmaninoff’s Third Piano Concerto all but secured his historic win. Yunchan played with grace and maturity very remarkable for his age. He displayed an understanding and control of the piece of a master. At the climax, as Yunchan played the heart-piercing chords in a cadenza, Marin Alsop, the conductor for all the finalists’ performances, struggled not to let some tears stream down. She had to catch her breath, awestruck by Yunchan’s virtuosity like the rest of the audience.

The ending of his performance was an overwhelming flow of emotions. The orchestra swayed to Yunchan and Alsop's lead. The sound of the orchestra grew, and the emotion from the performance permeated through the entire concert hall. As Yunchan triumphantly struck the last chord, roaring applause immediately came from the audience. Sean and Hear International remarked: "The applause that followed was endless: a star had emerged before our eyes."

The performance shook more than just the classical music world. The YouTube video of his performance became viral, trending globally as the #25 most-trending video and garnering 5.5 million views in less than one month. Yunchan's performance of the concerto quickly became the most viewed rendition of the piece, totaling more than 8 million views. Many considered it the best interpretation of Rachminonoff's work.

The result was unsurprising as the Cliburn announced the winner. Yunchan Lim became the youngest winner of the competition ever at just eighteen years old; he was awarded \$100,000 and three years of concerts and artistic management. Russian pianist Anna Geniushene and Ukrainian pianist Dmytro Choni won silver and bronze, respectively. The mood of the closing ceremony was triumphant. Wild applause welcomed each of the winners as their names were announced. The audience erupted into greater cheers as Yunchan was named the winner, acknowledging the history they were witnessing. Yunchan embraced his host family, who had burst into tears, overwhelmed by the joy of what he had just accomplished. He then walked onto the stage and was greeted by a gleaming Alsop as he accepted his awards.

Thus concluded the sixteenth edition of the Van Cliburn Competition. An eighteen-year-old Korean playing twentieth-century romantic Russian music with an American orchestra and conductor, bonded by the universal language of music, showed a world devoid of compassion from a raging pandemic and a cruel war the transcendent and remedial power of music.

The Van Cliburn Competition ended with the podium shared by a Korean, Russian, and Ukrainian—the unlikeliest group possible in Texas amidst the Russo-Ukrainian war. Their photo celebrating their medals is symbolic of more than just their individual victories; it is a victory of music and its ability to continually provide hope through hardship and hate.

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